Responses to Cantonese A-not-A questions by Cantonese-English bilingual children

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Introduction

- A target response to a Cantonese A-not-A question is a verb echo answer (VEA), which is to reduplicate the verb or adjective in the question, as in (1).

(1) A: Gin6 saam1 leng3-m4-leng3 aa3 ?
CL dress pretty-not-pretty SFP ?
'Does the dress look good?'
B: leng3 aa3
Pretty SFP
'Yes, it does.'

- Chan (1995) mentioned the occurrence of "minimal forms" *hai6* and *m4hai6* in children's responses to A-not-A questions without further explanation.
- We argue that "minimal forms", which is defined as mismatch in our study, is a result of cross-linguistic influence (CLI) from English.
- *Hai6/m4hai6* acts as an invariable response to Cantonese intonational and particle questions. It provides a polarity value to the question in a way similar to yes/no in English.
- The overlapping use of *hai6/m4hai6* and yes/no is necessary for the occurrence of CLI according to Hulk & Müller's (2000) hypothesis.
- Yip & Matthews (2000) showed that language dominance determines the directionality of CLI.

Hypotheses & Predictions

- Since we argue that one type of mismatch is a result of CLI and given that language dominance determines the directionality of CLI, the more Cantonese-dominant the child is, the less CLI from English there will be. Therefore, we predict:

1. Bilingual children produce more mismatch than monolingual children.
2. Within bilingual children, the more Cantonese-dominant the child is, the less mismatch they will produce.

Method

- We collected data from Hong Kong Bilingual Child Language Corpus (*N* = 8, Yip & Matthews, 2007) and Hong Kong Cantonese Child Language Corpus (*N* = 8, Lee et al., 1996).
- The corpus data are analyzed by sampling children's utterances at 3-month intervals from 2;0 to 3;0.
- Responses were categorized as 1) target response, 2) mismatch, and 3) others, including ignored questions, English response, and non-verbal response.
- Mixed-effects logistic regression modelling and post hoc analyses using estimated marginal means were conducted on our data.
- Language dominance is determined by the child's MLU differential, the direction of code-mixing, and language preference (Yip & Matthews, 2000).

Results & Discussion

- Two types of mismatch are found.
- Copular mismatch is to use *hai6* 'be' or *m4 hai6* 'not be' to answer non-*hai6-m4-hai6* A-not-A questions, as in (2).

(2) LIN: Gam2 nei5 zung1-m4-zung1ji3 tai2 aa3 ?
So you like-not-like watch SFP
'So do you like to watch it?'
CHI: Hai6 aa3
Be SFP
'Yes.' (Llywelyn, 2;06.20)

- Existential mismatch is to use *jau5* 'have' or *mou5* 'not have' to answer non-*jau5-mou5* A-not-A questions, as in (3).

(3) SIS: e6 Virginia hai2-m4-hai2 dou6 ?
Eh Virginia at-not-at here
'Eh, is Virginia here?'
CHI: Mou5
Not-have
'No, she is not.' (Alicia, 02;06.02)

- *Jau5* and *mou5* can be used to show presence and absence of an entity in Cantonese. This mismatch is a result of influence from their existential use in Cantonese.
- Bilingual children produced significantly more mismatches than monolingual children (*p* = .01) .

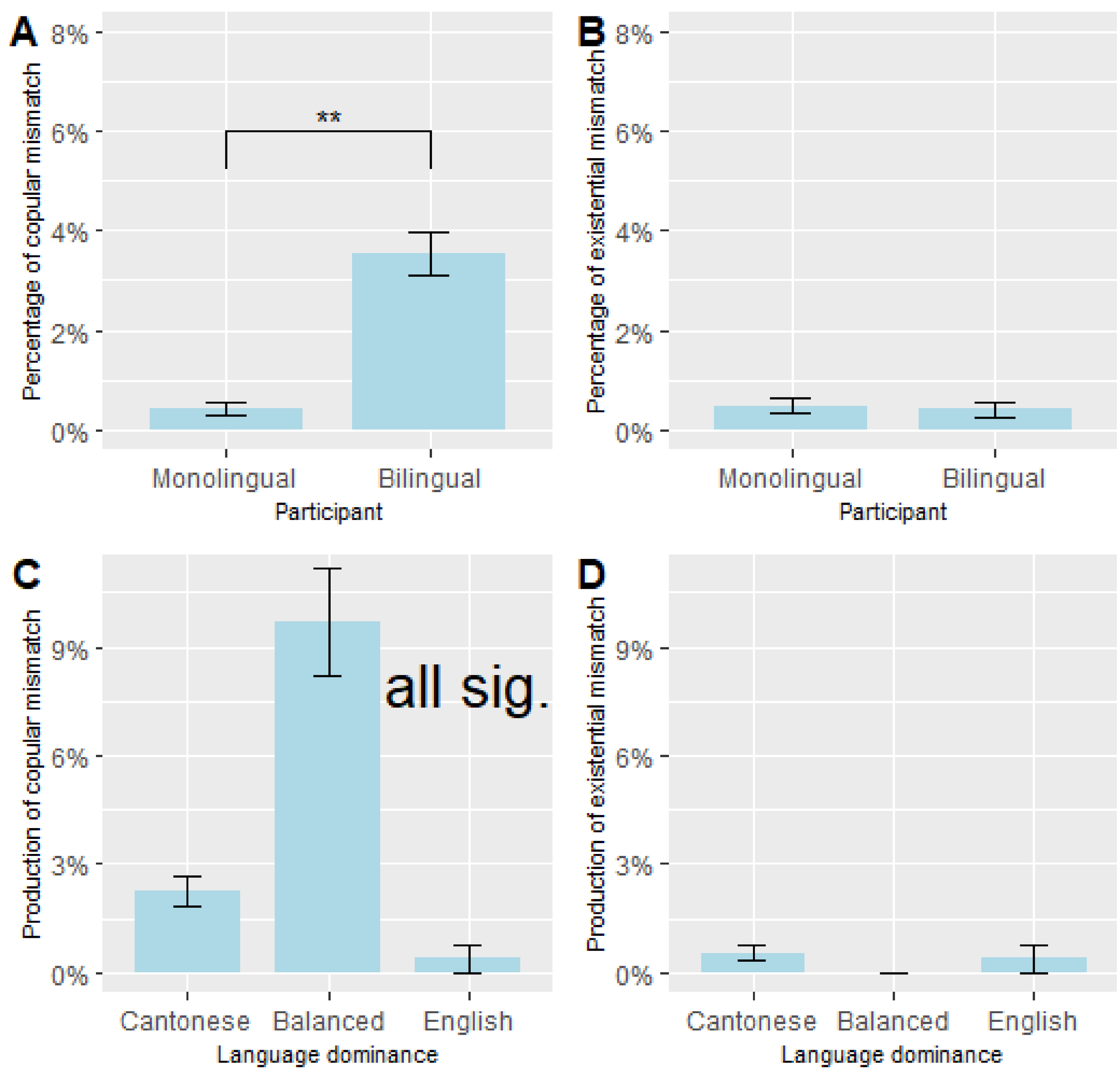

Figure 1. (A) Production of copular mismatch by monolingual and bilingual children; (B) Production of existential mismatch by monolingual and bilingual children; (C) Production of copular mismatch at three levels of language dominance; (D) Production of existential mismatch at three levels of language dominance
Error bar represents standard error, ***p* < .01

- Bilingual children produced significantly more copular mismatch than monolingual children (*p* < .01).
- Higher production rate of copular mismatch in bilingual children suggests that it is a result of CLI.
- There is no significant difference in the production of existential mismatch between bilingual and monolingual children.
- Balanced children produced significantly more copular mismatch than Cantonese-dominant (*p* < .001) and English-dominant children (*p* < .001). Cantonese-dominant children produced significantly more copular mismatch (*p* < .001), than English-dominant children.
- There is no significant difference in the production of existential mismatch between the three groups of bilingual children.
- The results partially support our second hypothesis.
- Not many Cantonese mismatches were observed in English-dominant children's production as they responded in English frequently.

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